

Impressionism

Rejected by the art establishment for their radical approach, in 1874, a group of artists exhibited independently in Paris. They included Monet, Renoir, Camille Pissarro (1830–1903), Edgar Degas (1834–1917), Cézanne, Alfred Sisley (1839–99), Frederic Bazille (1841–70), Mary Cassatt (1844–1926) and Berthe Morisot (1841–95). An art critic derisively nicknamed them ‘Impressionists’ after Monet’s painting *Impression, Sunrise*, and the name stuck. Capturing transitory moments, the Impressionists applied sketchy, rapid brushmarks and bright colours, often using newly-available synthetic pigments, emphasizing changing weather and qualities of light. They often painted *en plein air*, and many adopted Manet’s *alla prima* (‘at once’) technique. Most painted from unusual viewpoints and used colours in shadows. Contrasting with Académie preferences, they painted contemporary life, avoiding symbolism or underlying meanings. They extended ideas from Realism, the Barbizon School, Japanese prints, industry, scientific colour theories and Delacroix. Photography was also influential – both for its technique of working with light and as a practical aid.



Monet, *Impression, Sunrise*, 1872